

SSA Starter Worksheet

The simple starting point for a Social Security disability application — SSI or SSDI. The steps, the documents, and the timeline, all on a few pages you can check off as you go.

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How to use this worksheet: Check each box as you finish it. Fill in the lines with your own information. Keep it with your important documents and bring it to any appointment.

The Steps, At a Glance

Step 1 — Learn the programs. SSI is based on need (low income and resources). SSDI is based on work history. Some adults qualify for DAC benefits on a parent's record. Knowing which one fits saves time.

Step 2 — Gather your documents (checklist below).

Step 3 — Start the application at ssa.gov, by phone at 1-800-772-1213 (TTY 1-800-325-0778), or at your local Social Security office. The day you start protects your filing date — do not wait until everything is perfect.

Step 4 — Complete the reports. Social Security will ask for a disability report, a function report, and a work history report. Be complete and honest: describe a hard day, not the best day.

Step 5 — Keep medical care going. Gaps in treatment can hurt a claim. Go to appointments and keep records updated.

Step 6 — Watch the mail and answer everything. Most problems start with a missed letter. You may be sent to a consultative exam with Social Security's doctor — go, and be on time.

Step 7 — If denied, appeal on time. You generally have 60 days. Many strong cases are approved on appeal — a first denial is not the end.

What You Need — Document Checklist

- ☐ Birth certificate and Social Security card
- ☐ Proof of citizenship or legal status
- ☐ List of all doctors, hospitals, and clinics — with dates of visits
- ☐ Medical records and test results
- ☐ Medication list — name, dose, who prescribed it, and why
- ☐ Work history — jobs from the last 5 years, with duties and dates
- ☐ School records (for a child: IEPs, 504 plans, evaluations, teacher reports)
- ☐ Proof of income and resources (pay stubs, bank statements, tax returns)
- ☐ Names and contact information for people who know about the condition

How Long Does It Take?

A first decision commonly takes about **3 to 6 months**. If the first answer is no, the next step (reconsideration) can take a few more months. If the case goes to a hearing in front of a judge, the full path can take **1 to 2 years** in total. For SSDI there is a 5-month waiting period before payments begin. For SSI, payments generally start from the month after you apply or become eligible. These are common ranges — every case is different.

My Notes

Want the complete walk-through? The SSA Complete Packages (Child and Adult) pair a full worksheet with 2 guided Zoom sessions where we complete the application together. See southernoakfw.org or email southernoakfw@gmail.com.

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